Western front with Pakistan was as a Major when the unit was at Meerut in 1996–97. It was almost fifteen years since then, and the intervening years had mostly been spent in the East. The key staff appointments, Brig Vipul Shinghal, the BGS, and Brig Rajesh Pushkar, the Brig Q, had also just joined on termination of their Brigade Commands. The only old hand was the Col GS (Ops), Col Jitender Kumar, an AD officer.[1] I thought to myself that going ahead with the original date would be better as it would force me to familiarize myself that much faster. Work expands to fill the available time, and postponing the event would only mean that I would have less time to implement the lessons learnt from the WG. I therefore told the Army Commander that we would go ahead as planned.

The next six weeks went by in a whirl. We visited each of the Divisions, including the Artillery Division, the Indep Brigades—including the Indep AD Bde, commanded by Brig Vikrant Naik—and as many Brigades and units as possible. At each place, I only listened to what the commanders had to say, just letting all this information and an altogether different set of terminologies seep in. Since most of this was new to me, I would make copious notes and would sit down every evening making small aide-memoires on multicoloured 2" x 4" cards for my ready reference, poring over the maps of the area.

Over the years, given that the area of operations is more or less the same, all possible permutations and combinations have already been played. Year after year, there are only minor changes in terrain, a new bridge somewhere or a wider and better road somewhere else, an increment of a unit or two, but nothing that could make a radical difference to the plans. It was a common practice to dust off the plans of the last few WGs and see which of those could be played yet again, with some minor variations. We tried to make a somewhat different offensive

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation